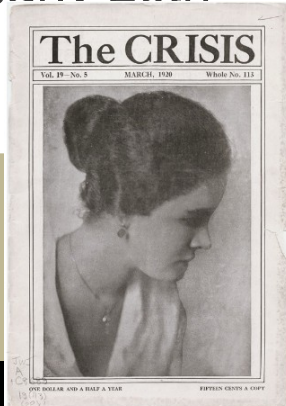


*Poetry: Shall I say, 'My
Son You're Branded'?" by
Georgia Douglas Johnson
- Poetry: "The Weary
Blues" by Langston
Hughes (77-80)*

Georgia Douglas Johnson: Biography & Background

- Georgia Douglas Johnson (1880–1966) major Harlem Renaissance poet
- hosted Langston Hughes, Zora Neale Hurston, & Countee Cullen
- poetry explored women's emotional struggles & social limits, especially in her first book, *The Heart of a Woman* (1918)
- Critics said early work lacked racial focus
 - *Bronze* (1922) addresses both race & gender
- Offers important perspective on Black women's experiences in early 20th century



Analysis of Georgia Douglas Johnson's "Shall I Say, 'My Son, You're Branded'?"

- Black mother doesn't know how to prepare son for racism & giving him hope("The Talk")
- Racism = staged performance
 - Black people are "branded" & restricted
- speaker fears that telling her son truth may be sad, but silence isn't good
- builds his inner strength, identity, & courage to face injustice
- reflects real threat of racial violence
- believed art & language could make a more just future
- highlights role of mothers & home in shaping resilience & social change

SELECTED WORK: "Shall I Say, 'My Son, You're Branded'?" by Georgia Douglas Johnson (1919)

Shall I say, "My son, you're branded in this country's pageantry,
By strange subtleties you're tethered, and no forum sets you free?"
Shall I mark the young lights fading through your soul-enchanted eye,
As the dusky pall of shadows screen the highway of your sky?

Or shall I, with love prophetic, bid you dauntlessly arise.
Spurn the handicap that clogs you, taking what the world denies,
Bid you storm the sullen fortress wrought by prejudice and wrong
With a faith that shall not falter, in your heart and on your tongue!

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You!